Harrowdown Hill from Palace of the End

By Judith Thompson

DAVID KELLY: I'm beginning to think that it's the greatest sin of our time. Knowing, and pretending that we don't know so that we won't be inconvenienced in any way. Do you understand what I am saying? I knew. Oh, the things I knew. And I did nothing.

INTRODUCTION

In 2003, an inspection team led by David Kelly, one of the world's foremost experts on nuclear, chemical and biological weapons, conducted a thorough review of the military capacity of the sovereign nation of Iraq. He advised Prime Minister Tony Blair there were NO weapons of mass destruction in Iraq.

Despite this information, British Prime Minister Tony Blair declared that Iraq was a serious threat to national security and was capable of striking with weapons of mass destruction. Dr Kelly spoke with the press "off the record" to denounce this information as false, but the invasion of Iraq continued as planned in March of 2003.

On July 18, 2003, Dr. David Kelly was found dead on Harrowdown Hill, near his home in Oxfordshire. Suicide? Murder? We may never know the truth surrounding his death or if the threat of weapons of mass destruction really did justify military action against Iraq.

The fictionalized monologue Harrowdown Hill by Judith Thompson, gives voice to what may have been going through Dr. Kelly's mind before his untimely death. Harrowdon Hill from The Palace of the End by Judith Thompson

DAVID KELLY: Can you imagine, knowing that a man is torturing a child in your basement, and just going on with your life? Knowing it is happening right under your feet, as you wait for the kettle to boil, as you tuck your own children in bed, as you work in the garden . . . the dim light is always there, the muffled sound of her screaming. You pretend to yourself, "It's the crows on the line," but in your belly you know it is her agony. He is cutting off

her fingers one by one, pulling out her eyes, her teeth . . . unimaginable torture. And this is something you know for certain; others my guess at it, many deny it, but you know it for certain and you don't tell anyone because you might lose something if you do. Your carefree life, your ability to be happy, your job. Your job. And if you lose your job, you lose your pension. And you don't want to lose your pension. They said . . . they admitted they needed to sex it up, for the people – the people of Britain were not going to send their boys to a war they didn't believe in. They would tie them down rather than see them go. They said we had to fill the people with fear, we had to remind them of WWII, they had to understand that the threat of Saddam was like the threat of the Nazis. We all knew that this was not true. We all knew that the casus belli was a lie. What could we do? We had no power. We just shook our heads and scurried away, little mouse men. We were not to talk; we had taken a vow of secrecy. If we wanted to hold onto our jobs, we had to keep our mouths shut. So. . . . I put my head in the sand.

I told myself . . "I am for the invasion. Saddam is a monster – no doubt about that. Regime change is a must. The people will dance in the streets, if only for a day." I told myself: "They are good men, Bush and Blair, and Berlusconi. They want good for the people. They will topple Saddam, give aid to the new government and be on their way."

I told myself lies. Have you ever? Have you ever told an unforgivable lie to yourself? (Long beat)

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A few weeks before the invasion, a friend of mine, an American ambassador to Sweden asked me what would happen to me if Iraq were invaded. And do you know what I answered? I said I would probably be found dead in the woods. They'll make much of that, after my death. It'll be all over the Internet. And the funny thing is, I can't explain it. I was making a kind of morbid joke. But maybe I knew something that I didn't know I knew, you know?

At the start of the war I would wake up at six, watch the news every morning, from my bed. Each day's smooth account of bombings and causalities, and "collateral damage." I watched, hoping against hope that things would . . . would get better, but it soon became very clear to me that things were far, far, far worse for the Iraqi people than even I could have imagined.

What did I do? Did I go scream in the streets? Did I write to the papers? No. I did nothing. Nothing at all.

I became . . . clumsy. Yes, that was the only giveaway. I burned myself on the stove, I cut myself chopping onions, and I fell flat on my face on the pavement. I crashed into people in hallways, sat on my glasses, dropped the phone constantly, dropped and broke plates, couldn't eat without dribbling, staining all of my shirts with food. I was in great demand. Flying to conferences all over the world. With stained shirts and broken glasses. The truth about Weapons of Mass Destruction – that's what everyone wanted to know. I skirted the truth, bobbed and weaved, but I loved to hear my own voice -- loved to be regarded as the expert – the

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world expert – on biological weapons. Nominated for a Nobel Peace prize for my work in Russia ten years before: uncovering Stalinist secrets – disarming the next Black Plague and that is how they always introduced me. I talked to the press incessantly, my words always precise, witty – always filtered, always bloody lies. Walked through a screen door in Houston Texas, and feel into a river in Bern. Bit my tongue constantly. That was maybe the worst.

And then one day, one sunny June morning I was in New York City, just leaving the UN, I received a phone call from my dear old friend Jalal. He owned a bookstore in Baghdad, called in English, the Date Palm Tree. It was my favorite bookstore in the world, and I have been to almost all of them. No, I truly have! It's what I do in my down time, wherever I am. Well, Jalal was one of the most kind and joyful and learned men I had ever known. Oh, you would live his family – Marwa, well, Marwa, and she wouldn't mind me saying this at all, is sort of an Arabic Lucille Ball – she would turn the act of getting ice out of the fridge into this huge comic routine, have us all on the floor shouting with laughter. And their daughter, Sahar, I think she had just turned thirteen last time I saw them. She was obsessed with Anne of Green Gables. And Tabarek – the naughtiest five-year-old boy in the Universe, had to climb everything he say – tables, fridges, walls, people. I became . . . so . . . so close to this family. I loved that family – they became, in a way, my best friends in the world.

He said they were watching her. Sahar, his 13 year old. She was a very pretty girl, like a magazine model, I suppose, tall for her age, beautiful

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smile, a woman's figure but still very much a little girl – a happy child who loved her stuffed animals. And he said the American soldiers were watching her. He said they looked at her like a wolf looks at a rabbit. They were ravenous. There was evil in their eyes, he said. Blood. He said he planned to move her the next day, to take her to another town, to stay with her cousins. He wanted to know if I could speak to someone. I said I was sorry, but there really wasn't anyone I could speak to, even if they had been British. And then I reassured him. I told him not to worry; I said they were probably bored young hicks from Alabama who couldn't put two words together. Intimidating young girls – their only entertainment. I reassured him that they were carefully monitored by their commanding officers, and they would never dare approach her.

"If you could only see their eyes," he said. Even when he was with her, they would look her up and down, and say what were clearly crude things and laugh. She would go home and cry in her mother's arms. I told him again not to worry. I was sure everything would be fine. Not two days later, according to the New York Times, four American soldiers confronted Jalal and his Sahar outside his bookstore. Took them inside. Said they were looking for weapons. For insurgents. "There are only books, please take all the books you want," said Jalal, according to a witness. Once in the store they took Sahar aside. Rounded up Marwa and Tabarek, took the three of them into the basement. And shot them. The killer climbed the stairs and said, "I've killed them. They're all dead." And then the four soldiers threw Sahar to the floor, raped the child. Put a bayonet through the child and shot her in the fact.

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They then set fire to the bookstore. *(He is having rouble breathing)* The press initially said it was the work of insurgents. "The terrorists." Until two soldiers from the same battalion as the killers were captured and beheaded on camera. One of the four, tortured with guilt over his comrades deaths, certain it had been revenge for the murders, confessed.

Oh, the things I knew. And I did nothing.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier

****NOTE: Nationals and State records did not designate which monologue from A Palace of the End was performed for competition.***

Cuttings from each monologue: My Pyramids, Harrowdown Hill and Instruments of Yearning are stored in the VAULT for review.

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